

The feeling of success for a civil servant

Ask any civil servant what success looks like, and the answer usually follows a familiar **script**: key postings, **steady** upward movement, a few major assignments, and finally, retirement at the top of the service. That version of success is **neat**. It's visible. It photographs well.

But speak to enough officers — across batches, services, and stages — and a quieter truth emerges: you can have all the **markers** of success and still not feel it. You can feel deeply fulfilled in a post that no one has ever called “significant.” **That** gap between what success looks and feels like **is** real. And learning how to close it is one of the most valuable skills a civil servant can develop.

A 2020 **study** in the Journal of Positive Psychology **found** that people who felt successful, not just those who were objectively successful, **tended to** report greater life satisfaction, **resilience**, and motivation.

In plain terms, how we process and frame our journey matters more than how others see it. That's especially true in public service, where you don't always control where you're posted, how long you stay, or whether your best work gets noticed. But you can control how you engage with the work itself. And that, more than anything, determines whether or not you feel successful.

Success in service **often** looks most satisfying when experienced in motion: a scheme that finally gets **traction** after weeks of meetings, a budget that closes clean, a team that begins to function without drama. These are not dramatic moments. But they **carry weight**.

Psychologists call this the progress principle, the feeling of forward motion in meaningful tasks. It's one of the strongest **predictors** of long-term motivation and satisfaction.

The officer who reworks a **clunky** departmental process so it runs smoothly. The one who brings coordination into a district team that had stopped talking to each other. The one who sees a project to completion, down to the last report. These are not heroic acts. They're acts of **artistry**. And for many in public service, they're the deepest source of pride.

The civil services are not **uniform** across all their scale and structures. Some careers move fast. Others **meander**. Some peak early. Others arrive quietly at the top after years of steady contribution.

And some officers, despite effort and **competence**, don't make it to the top **rung**. But here's what they often have: the respect of colleagues, the satisfaction of seeing systems work better because they were there, and the personal **rhythm** of doing the job well, over and over again. A career doesn't have to be celebrated to be complete. It just has to feel like it was put to good use.

Whether starting, mid-career, or nearing the finish line, here are four things that make a difference, not to how successful you look, but how successful you feel.

Most civil servants are **wired** to focus on what hasn't been done yet. But looking back at what you've helped move — projects, teams, processes — **grounds** you. It builds continuity. It gives you a personal story that's worth carrying.

Whether writing a clear note, managing a review meeting that ends with clarity, or helping colleagues solve problems faster, minor **refinements** matter. They keep you engaged. They turn routine into rhythm.

Not everything worth doing will be seen. Not every assignment comes with a stage. But if your day left the system slightly better — more functional, more responsive —that's meaningful. You don't need **applause** to confirm it.

Some of the most **enduring** satisfaction in service **comes** from teams that work. They are not perfect, but they are the kind where people solve problems together, argue respectfully, and get things done. **That** environment, when it clicks, **is** worth more than any posting.

There's a belief that once you reach the highest office, the satisfaction is automatic. But many senior officers will quietly **admit**: the view from the top is not always clear. The scope is **vast**, the time pressures intense, and decisions are more **distant** from implementation. Success in civil service isn't a final destination. It's not a title or a retirement speech. It's a pattern of doing the work well, over time, in ways that make things function a little better.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Script** (noun) – narrative, storyline, outline, format, plan पटकथा
2. **Steady** (adjective) – stable, consistent, firm, reliable, unchanging स्थिर
3. **Neat** (adjective) – tidy, orderly, clean, simple, elegant सुव्यवस्थित
4. **Marker** (noun) – indicator, sign, symbol, signal, milestone संकेत / चिह्न
5. **Tend** (to) (verb) – be inclined to, be likely to, usually, have a tendency, be prone to प्रवृत्त होना
6. **Resilience** (noun) – toughness, adaptability, endurance, strength, flexibility मजबूती
7. **Often** (adverb) – frequently, regularly, repeatedly, commonly, usually अक्सर
8. **Traction** (noun) – progress, momentum, grip, movement, advancement गति / पकड़
9. **Carry weight** (phrase) – be important, be influential, matter, have value, be significant महत्व रखना
10. **Psychologist** (noun) – mental health expert, therapist, counselor, shrink, analyst – मनोवैज्ञानिक
11. **Predictor** (noun) – indicator, forecaster, signal, sign, clue भविष्यवक्ता / सूचक
12. **Clunky** (adjective) – awkward, inefficient, unpolished, cumbersome, rough भद्दा / बेढंगा
13. **Artistry** (noun) – creativity, craftsmanship, skill, finesse, talent कलात्मकता / शिल्प
14. **Uniform** (adjective) – consistent, standardized, identical, equal, same एकरूप
15. **Meander** (noun) – wandering, deviation, digression, drift, winding path घूमावदार रास्ता / भटकाव
16. **Competence** (noun) – ability, skill, proficiency, efficiency, qualification दक्षता
17. **Rung** (noun) – level, step, tier, stage, grade पायदान
18. **Rhythm** (noun) – flow, pattern, tempo, beat, routine लय / ताल
19. **Wire** (verb) – program, train, prepare, condition, configure स्वाभाविक रूप से तैयार करना
20. **Ground** (verb) – anchor, establish, root, base, stabilize आधार देना
21. **Refinement** (noun) – improvement, polishing, enhancement, adjustment, upgrade परिष्कार
22. **Applause** (noun) – praise, clapping, acclaim, admiration, recognition प्रशंसा

23. **Enduring** (adjective) – lasting, long-lasting, persistent, perpetual, continuous टिकाऊ / दीर्घकालिक

24. **Admit** (verb) – acknowledge, confess, accept, concede, allow स्वीकार करना

25. **Vast** (adjective) – immense, enormous, extensive, massive, huge विशाल

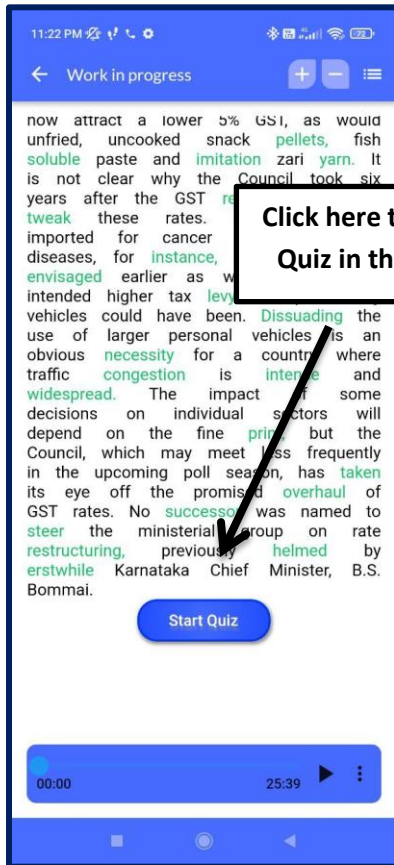
26. **Distant** (adjective) – far, remote, detached, removed, aloof दूर

@mocks_wallah

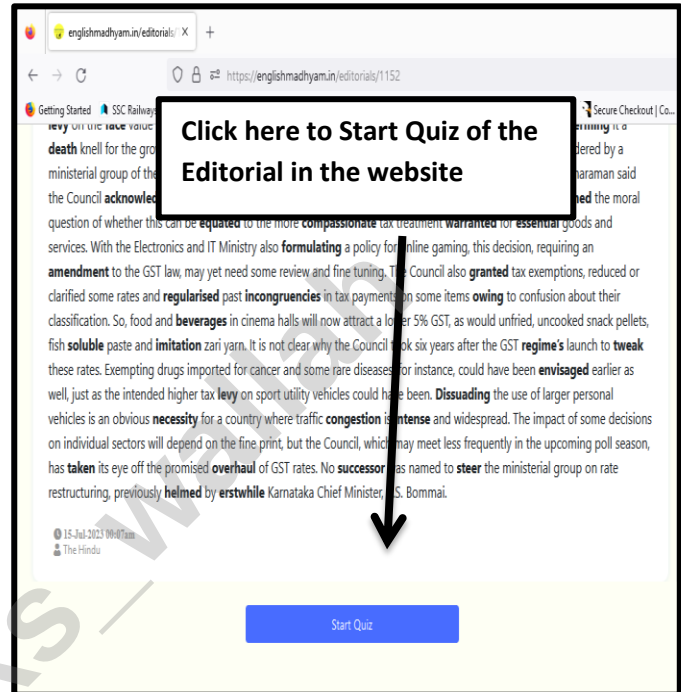
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Traditional success** in civil services is often defined by visible achievements like key postings, upward mobility, and a top-level retirement.
2. Despite this standard model, many officers feel **unfulfilled** even after reaching those conventional milestones.
3. There is a **disconnect between the appearance and the feeling of success** — the latter being more important for true satisfaction.
4. A study shows that people who **feel successful**, rather than just appear successful, enjoy greater motivation, resilience, and life satisfaction.
5. In public service, external recognition is often limited, so it's crucial to **focus on how one engages with their work**.
6. Small wins — like implementing a new process or streamlining meetings — provide a deep sense of **satisfaction and purpose**.
7. This aligns with the **"progress principle"** — the idea that consistent progress in meaningful work leads to lasting motivation.
8. Acts like improving systems, coordinating teams, or completing projects are **quiet but meaningful achievements**.
9. Civil service careers vary — some rise fast, others slowly — but **contribution, not recognition, defines true success**.
10. Even without top positions, officers can feel fulfilled through **respect, effectiveness, and repeated quality work**.
11. Reflecting on what's been accomplished, rather than what's left undone, helps build a **personal narrative of success**.
12. Small daily improvements — like better notes or efficient meetings — **sustain engagement** and transform routine into rhythm.
13. Many meaningful contributions in civil service go **unseen and unrewarded**, but they still matter deeply.
14. The most enduring workplace joy often comes from **functional, respectful teams that solve problems together**.
15. True success in civil service isn't a **final title** but a **lifetime pattern** of doing work well, making systems better, and finding purpose in the everyday.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



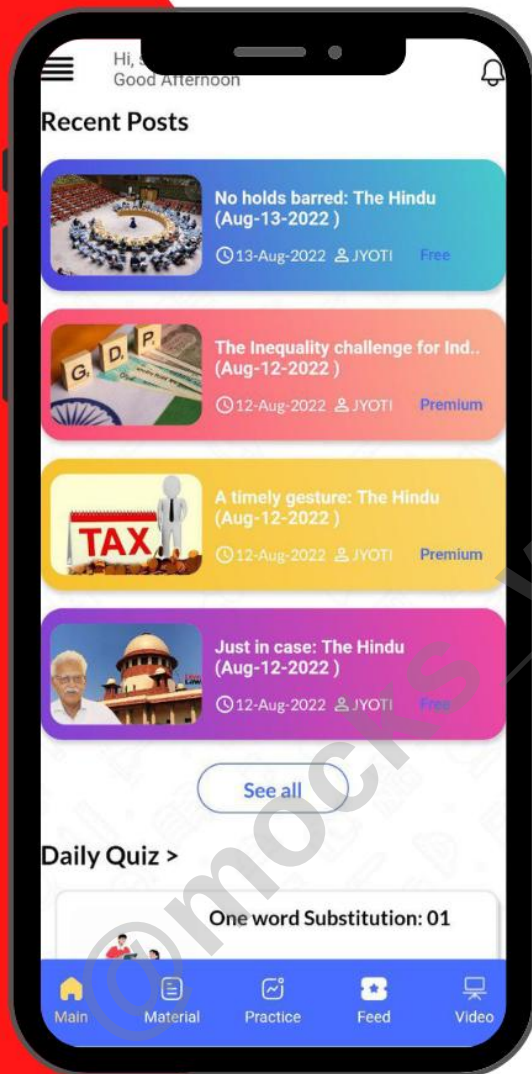
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